

Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

SATURDAY, AUGUST 16, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Cupich celebrates 50 years as a priest

‘Every day was an opportunity to live out my priesthood’

By Angie Leventis Lourgos
Chicago Tribune

In one of the most exhilarating moments in his half century as a priest, Cardinal Blase Cupich watched in awe from an adjacent balcony in May as newly-elected Chicago native Pope Leo XIV gave his first address to the world on the loggia of St. Peter's Basilica,

While the experience was unprecedented, the head of the Chicago Archdiocese says he has felt that same spirit of joy and elation laced throughout his five-decade career, ever since he was ordained Aug. 16, 1975.

“I have to say that I brought the same excitement of that day to every day that I've been a priest,” he told the Tribune during a recent interview. “I've always looked for moments in which being a priest could be a benefit to other people.”

Cupich will celebrate the 50th anniversary of his ordination with a golden jubilee Mass at 5:15 p.m. Saturday at Holy Name Cathedral in Chicago. The service will be livestreamed for those who can't attend in person.

Despite major challenges facing the global Catholic Church — from financial woes to ongoing fallout from the church sex abuse crisis — Cupich says his love for pastoring and service hasn't waned since his ordination five decades ago.

“Whether I was teaching kids in high school my first years after I was ordained or serving in the Vatican embassy in Washington, D.C., or being the pastor of a parish, and then of course being named bishop, I always felt that every day was an opportunity to live out my priesthood,” he added.

Born in Omaha, Nebraska, in 1949, the grandson of Croatian immigrants believes his roots helped shape his ministry and leadership, particularly in an ethnically and racially diverse part of the country such as Chicago, where he was installed as archbishop in 2014.

At the helm of the third-largest Catholic archdiocese in the country, he serves roughly 2 million Catholics at 216 parishes.

Cupich, the third of nine children in a devoutly Catholic home, recalled his grandparents “tried as immigrants to come here and start a life and family that would become more prosperous than where they came from.”

“And I think that is the story of all immigrants,” the 76-year-old cardinal said. “That's why I'm so very focused on immigrants' rights, not

Turn to Cupich, Page 4



ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/TRIBUNE

Illini QB comfortable with preseason buzz

Entering his third season as starting quarterback, Luke Altmyer welcomes the lofty expectations for the team. **Chicago Sports**

SNAP food education program nears end

Funding to run out in September for initiative aimed at addressing the root causes of health disparities. **Chicagoland, Page 3**



President Donald Trump greets Russian President Vladimir Putin on Friday at Joint Base Elmendorf-Richardson in Alaska. JULIA DEMAREE NIKHINSON/AP

Summit in Alaska holds potential to reshape war

Trump, Putin meet for talks on ending conflict in Ukraine

By Michelle L. Price and Will Weissert
Associated Press

JOINT BASE ELMENDORF-RICHARDSON, Alaska — President Donald Trump said he and Vladimir Putin didn't reach a deal to end Russia's war in Ukraine after meeting on Friday — despite Putin saying they had come to “an understanding” — as the two leaders offered scant

details on what was discussed while heaping praise on each other.

In brief remarks as they shared a stage after meeting for about 2 ½ hours in Alaska, Putin said he and Trump had reached an “understanding” on Ukraine and warned Europe not to “torpedo the nascent progress.”

But Trump then said, “There's no deal until there's a deal” and said he planned to speak with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy and European leaders soon, to brief them on the discussions.

“We had an extremely productive meeting, and many points

were agreed to,” Trump said. “And there are just a very few that are left. Some are not that significant. One is probably the most significant, but we have a very good chance of getting there.”

He continued: “We didn't get there.”

The high-profile summit ended without a deal to end, or even pause, the brutal conflict — the largest land war in Europe since 1945 — which has raged for more than three years. The two were expected to hold a joint news conference but instead took turns giving brief remarks. Putin went first and then Trump, but both left without taking questions.

Just getting back to the United States for the first time in a decade was a win for Putin, whom the U.S. and much of the world had long been attempting to isolate.

Agreeing to travel to Alaska to meet with Trump also stalled economic sanctions that Trump had promised unless Moscow worked harder to bring fighting to a close. The outcome could also benefit Russia's leader since Friday's meeting may simply lead to more such meetings in the future.

Russia's forces are making fair progress on the battlefield,

Turn to Summit, Page 6



Brothers Alfredo Pacheco, left, and Jose Gregorio Gonzalez prepare for a living kidney transplant on Thursday at the University of Illinois Hospital in Chicago. HOSS FATEMI/UI HEALTH MARKETING

ICE spared him from deportation. He saved his brother with a kidney

Venezuelan was arrested in Cicero weeks before process was to begin

By Laura Rodríguez Presa
Chicago Tribune

The minutes dragged into hours on Wednesday night as Jose Gregorio Gonzalez tossed and turned through the night. At 5 a.m. the next day, he was scheduled to donate his kidney to his younger brother, Alfredo Pacheco, who was also restless.

By 2 a.m. the two couldn't stay in bed any longer and began to get ready for a day that they

thought would never come.

“Es un milagro, porque todo estaba contra nosotros,” Gonzalez said. “It's a miracle, because all odds were against us.”

His mind raced back to the nights he spent locked inside an immigration detention center earlier this year, convinced he would soon be deported, while his younger brother pleaded with ICE officials to let him stay.

Gonzalez was Pacheco's only hope to keep living after being

diagnosed with terminal renal failure. When doctors told Pacheco he needed a kidney transplant, Gonzalez stepped up. “Nunca lo pensé dos veces,” Gonzalez said in Spanish. “I didn't think about it twice.”

But in March, just shy of a few weeks to begin the process for the transplant, Gonzalez was suddenly arrested by U.S. Immigration and Customs

Turn to Brothers, Page 4

Lawmaker hopes kids learn ‘dad fought back’

Texans set to leave Illinois after taking a stand on legislative map

By Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

John Bucy's older daughter “seemed a little frustrated” with him this week when he wasn't home to take her to school for her first day of kindergarten.

The Texas House lawmaker from Austin hopes one day she'll understand.

For the past two weeks, Bucy has been one of nearly three dozen Texas Democrats who, after fleeing their state in the middle of a legislative special session, have holed up at a secure hotel in far west suburban St. Charles. Invited here by Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker, the Texans' goal was to prevent the Republicans who control their legislature and governor's office from using the special session to draw a new congressional map during the middle of the decade that could have national implications by helping the GOP retain its narrow control of the U.S. House through the remainder of President Donald Trump's time in the White House.

While the standoff appeared to be drawing to a close as the Texas Democrats vowed late this week to head back home once the

Turn to Texans, Page 2

